Dolores

By Edward Allan Baker

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Sandra is home alone, enjoying her weekly break from her husband and kids, when her older sister Dolores shows up with a black eye, courtesy of the latest in her string of bad husbands.*
ACTRESS 2: *Dolores is the story of siblings and spouses, bruises and bullets, in which two sisters with two very different kinds of heartache must confront the anguish behind every routine that life imposes.*
ACTRESS 1: *It takes the punishing love of family and one shocking act of violence to remind them that every kind of love has its own darkness and that every plea for mercy is one for understanding.*
TOGETHER: *Dolores by Edward Allen Baker*

*As scene opens, Sandra is dancing and singing to the *Will You Love Me Tomorrow? by the Shirelles while removing items from a shopping bag atop the table. Enter Dolores.*

DOLORES: **(Pg 175-196)** Uh . . . Sandra?

SANDRA: *(Sandra spins and sees Dolores, then quickly turns off the music; angrily)* NO! OUT!

DOLORES: Please! I gotta stay here! He wants to kill me!

SANDRA: I'm sick a' this, Dolores! Out!

DOLORES: He's afta' me!

SANDRA: I don't care!

DOLORES: What is wrong with you?! He wants ta' kill me! You think I'm kiddin'?!

SANDRA: I don't want to get involved! I mean it! I'm sick a' only seein' you when you got problems!

DOLORES: Let me stay for a little while till . . .

SANDRA: NO! Whenever I help you, it turns into a horror show!

DOLORES: I'm scared, Sandra!

SANDRA: When are you gonna' learn?! Huh? How many more f****ed-up guys you goin' ta' marry?! An don't pull the tears on me! This is my only time alone. Sunday aftanoon Vinnie takes the kids to the park, then to his Mother's, an' it's my only time away from all the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

aggravation, ya' unda'stand?

DOLORES: *(removes sunglasses, revealing a black eye)* Just for a little while, then I'll go, okay? *(Sandra looks at black eye)* I don't want to get hit no more or yelled at . . . I'm so tired of bein' yelled at an' . . .

SANDRA: *(manages to break free from Dolores)* An' whose fault is it, Dolores? You pick these nuts ta marry an afta' six months you come runnin' to everybody! We all try to tell you not to marry these **idiots*,* but you never listened. Then we go to your stupid weddings an' listen to the same song you pick out as you're walkin' down the aisle . . . "We've Only Just Begun."

DOLORES: *(softly, wiping her eyes)* I love that song . . .

SANDRA: But we're all laughin'. Don't ya' know that?

DOLORES: Let me stay just for tonight and . . .

SANDRA: *(cuts her off)* No! Vinnie would never have you stay here, an' me an' him been gettin' along pretty good lately an' I don't wanna break it. I don't need 'im seein' you here 'cause he'll turn right around an' split, an' I don't need that shit on top a' everything else! I got my little house with my little kitchen where I feed my little kids an' Vinnie brings home his little paycheck an' if there's a little extra on Fridays we go out to Valle's by the Airport for a little steak an' salad, then to a show. I got three Dustbusters, a coupon drawer an' I'm savin' stamps for a VCR!

DOLORES: *(after a beat)* You're so lucky . . . Does Vinnie ever hit you?

SANDRA: Of course not. Shove here, a shove there . . .

DOLORES: We ***all*** get shoved, Sandra. I'm talkin' about whacked, kicked, pushed down stairs, hair pulled back, woken up in the middle of the night for hard sex, insulted in a restaurant, pushed outta' a car . . . What if he's out there waitin' for me?!

SANDRA: I don't know. Talk it out with him. He doesn't seem that bad. Except for his crooked eye, he seems normal so just figure it out for ya'self! Go to the police!

DOLORES: Forget that! They don't do nothin'! I been through it before, an' they come an' usually stick up for the guy. Unless there's a knife comin' outta your heart! You're not really

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

goin' to throw me out there, are you?

SANDRA: Dolores . . . I got . . . I got my own life here, an' stuff you get involved in is so way above my head. I mean . . . he hit you an' well, you gotta work it out with him. Vinnie an' I get along fine 'cause most times we walk around here an' we just don't talk. We watch television an' on Fridays he gets what he wants an' we just go on and . . .

DOLORES: *(cuts Sandra off)* I don't want that! I want more than that, for Chrissakes. No talkin' an watchin' TV . . . if I wanted that I never woulda' left Frankie!

SANDRA: Oh c'mon . . . Frankie ate his spaghetti an' meatballs with his hands an' couldn't talk straight!

DOLORES: *(Looks away)* When I first met Jerry . . . I was, was down in the pits. I felt I had no family, I had no kids, no nothin' an' I was thirty years old. Goin' to the bars lookin' around at other thirty-year-old women. I couldn't watch TV no more 'cause family scenes made me sob and the music on the radio, especially Carly Simon songs, made me all soft inside . . . like I was dyin' for somebody to just touch my hand! I'd . . . I'd look at some guy, you know, an' think to myself, "oh, please let him say something nice to me 'cause I'm the one for him . . . " an' I would just pray he could pick it up in my eyes, but too many times nothin' like that ever happened. I'd look in the mirra' an'-an' my face always looked dirty and I would scrub it till it was red! Then one night I looked over an' saw Jerry lookin' at me . . . an' I forgot bein' lonely an' the family, an' other women! Help me! Help me get through this, Sandra!

SANDRA: *(snaps)* WHAT?! WHAT DO YOU WANT ME TO DO?! What?! Put you in the cellar?! Hide you in the closet?!

DOLORES: I need some help, I need support. I'm good, Sandra, an' everybody comes down on me 'cause I don't like gettin' beat up! I'm supposed ta put up with it 'cause Ma did?! That's not what my shrink told me.

SANDRA: *(surprised) You* see a shrink? Where do you get money to see a shrink?

DOLORES: It's only a buck a week or whatever you can afford, kinda like welfare shrinks in this clinic on Cranston Street. They listen for half an hour an' ya get stuff out, but I don't feel any different. It's like when you're a kid leavin' confession an' ya' feel good for about twenty

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

minutes. I try things this woman says, but I don't know if I really believe in all that *crap*,

SANDRA: Okay, okay. Does this shrink say any thin' about him an' what you should do about it?

DOLORES: Oh, yeah. That I should . . . uh . . . confront him more an' make him aware of problems that I have with him. Stuff you read in *Seventeen* magazine, an' I tell her "Yeah, easy for you ta say cause you're not in front of the mean green eye a' his" an' she says "true."

SANDRA: Hold it. Have you talked ta Jerry like she said you should?

DOLORES: If you got a problem with Vinnie, say he did some disgustin' thing that pissed you off, do you sit down with him to discuss it? Do you say "Gee, Vin . . . you look so ugly in ya' boxer shorts an' ya' gettin fat"

SANDRA: Wait a . . .

DOLORES: *(continuing)* Or "Gee, Vin . . . are you as confused about God as me, an' do you think that we're slowly becomin' the parents we fought with?" You ever see Ma an' Dad talk when we were kids? *(A beat)* What do you do, Sandra, when you got a problem with "The Big Vin?" Huh? What clues do you give 'im that something's wrong? Maybe slide his plate in front of him a little harda' than usual?

SANDRA: We . . . just get by it . . . and . . .

DOLORES: An' it disappears, right?

SANDRA: Look . . . we . . . I don't have the problems you have, Dolores. The kids take up a lotta time and . . . *(angrily)* I think you should go now! Really . . . put ya' coat on an' leave! Of everybody who deals with you, I am the straightest when it comes to tellin' you stuff! *(throws Dolores her coat, moving her to the door)*

DOLORES: *(holds her hand up)* SSSH!

SANDRA: Don't tell me to . . .

DOLORES: *(waves)* Be quiet for a . . . *(Sandra watches Dolores walk to the door and listen; she reaches for her Dustbuster and holds it like weapon)* You hear something?

SANDRA: *(close to Dolores)* No . . . I . . .

DOLORES: SSSH! *(beat)* There's someone out there . . . *(returning to table)* Footsteps. First one .

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

. . then another. *(beat)* Oh god . . . I'm sorry . . . *(they face each other)* Do you think it's nut house time?

SANDRA: I . . .

DOLORES: I might not have a choice . . .

SANDRA: *(softly)* A nut house might be good.

DOLORES: You think?

SANDRA: Maybe.

DOLORES: People be there to help.

SANDRA: True . . .

DOLORES: On Sunday afta'noons you could come an' sing to me . . . *(sings, softly)* "Will you still love me tomorrow?" *(beat)*

SANDRA: *(crosses in front of Dolores)* Uh . . . so listen . . . if Vinnie does come home . . . I'm goin' to tell him that, uh . . . you're here an' that I talked you into gettin' help at a, you know . . . a head hospital, all right? If he comes in, all right? That way there'll be no trouble or yellin' an' he'll understand. *(beat)* An' I lied before about when I said that, uh, Vinnie only shoved me. He's hit me. It started with the dog. He really used to go **off** on the dog an' sometimes for no reason. Just start beltin' it an' gettin' mean. *(beat)* One time last year me an' Vinnie was drivin' back from his mother's an' we were at a light over on Atwells Avenue, an' this motorcycle pulled up next to my window and I looked over an' saw this good-lookin' guy on the bike . . . kinda like Al Pacino with blue eyes an' he had on a brown leather jacket, pair a' ripped-up jeans an' boots. An' he smiled at me, then winked . . . just like in a TV commercials! I couldn't take my eyes off a' him . . . an' then . . . I felt my hair bein' pulled an' before I knew it, my head was on the seat, an' I was bein' punched in the face! Not slapped, but punched! Same way he used to hit the dog and I . . . I could hear the motorcycle way off in the distance . . . *(pause)* Something went away with that guy . . . *(shakes it off, rubbing her eyes)*

DOLORES: Don't worry about it . . .

SANDRA: That's it! You're staying here! I'll take care a' Vinnie. I'll take care a' him . . .

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DOLORES: Sandra. . .

SANDRA: *(angry, upset)* I mean you're my sista', damn it! *(beat)* If we can't even . . . *(beat)* What's the point?!

DOLORES: I . . . I shot him, Sandra. This mornin.' I shot him. He hit me too many times, an' he won't let me outta his sight . . .

SANDRA: No, you didn't . . . tell me ya' didn't . . .

DOLORES: I couldn't take it no more an' Jerry was readin' the paper at the table an' I had his gun that I took from his coat an' I aimed it at a picture of Reagan that was on the front page, and I shot through the picture an' Jerry went flyin' back onto the floor an' he . . . he was laughin' . . . his shoulder was bleedin' and I ran out an' heard him say that he could kill me now, and I ran down the middle of Holmewood Street an' heard him in the car beepin' the horn and I kept runnin' an' could see people goin' to church and pickin' up their papers an' I cut . . . I cut through the Kentucky Fried Chicken place an' ran up the hill to Whitmarsh Street an' got on a bus. . . an' then I came here . . .

SANDRA: . . . uh oh, God . . . *(confused)* Uh . . . why didn't you *(Dolores looks up at Sandra)* I didn't know it was that bad. *(silence)* Shit, Dolores . . . I don't know what to say . . . I . . . *(Phone rings. Sandra is shocked for a beat then answers)* Hello . . . *(beat)* Yeah . . . she's here . . . what? *(takes a deep breath)* I guess so right, right . . . I know . . . I'll bring her an' shut up, Mary Ann! 'Cause I'm bringin' her! Fine . . . right bye . . . *(hangs up phone and turns to Dolores, who appears drained of all emotion)* Police found Jerry in his car . . . dead. Bled to death on Broad street. *(A chill passes through Dolores. She takes a deep breath and slowly exhales)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Edward Allan Baker
Book: The Best Short Plays 1989, Pgs 175-196
ISBN: 978-1557830456
Publisher: Applause Theatre Books
Date (Month/Year): Dec 1991

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier - MS
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier

* ***Will You Love Me Tomorrow? by the Shirelles***
Music and lyrics can be found at ***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Y2e8B2CmicQ***

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY